

Markdown

Markdown^[9] is a lightweight markup language for creating formatted text using a plain-text editor. John Gruber created Markdown in 2004 as an easy-to-read markup language.^[9] Markdown is widely used for blogging, instant messaging, and large language models,^[10] and also used elsewhere in online forums, collaborative software, documentation pages, and readme files.

The initial description of Markdown^[11] contained ambiguities and raised unanswered questions, causing implementations to both intentionally and accidentally diverge from the original version. This was addressed in 2014 when long-standing Markdown contributors released CommonMark, an unambiguous specification and test suite for Markdown.^[12]

History

Markdown was inspired by pre-existing conventions for marking up plain text in email and usenet posts,^[13] such as the earlier markup languages setext (c. 1992), Textile (c. 2002), and reStructuredText (c. 2002).^[9]

In 2002, Aaron Swartz created atx and referred to it as "the true structured text format". Gruber created the Markdown language in 2004 with Swartz as his "sounding board".^[14] The goal of the language was to enable people "to write using an easy-to-read and easy-to-write plain text format, optionally convert it to structurally valid XHTML (or HTML)".^[5]

Another key design goal was *readability*, that the language be readable as-is, without looking like it has been marked up with tags or formatting instructions,^[9] unlike text formatted with "heavier" markup languages, such as Rich Text Format (RTF), HTML, or even wikitext, each of which have obvious in-line tags and formatting instructions which can make the text more difficult for humans to read.

Gruber wrote a Perl script, Markdown.pl, which converts marked-up text input to valid, well-formed XHTML or HTML, encoding angle brackets (<, >) and ampersands (&), which would be misinterpreted as special characters in those languages. It can take the role of a standalone script, a plugin for Blosxom or Movable Type, or of a text filter for BBEdit.^[5]

Markdown



Filename extensions	.md, .markdown ^{[1][2]}
Internet media type	text/markdown ^[2]
Uniform Type Identifier (UTI)	net.daringfireball.markdown
UTI conformation	public.plain-text
Magic number	None
Developed by	<u>John Gruber</u>
Initial release	March 9, 2004 ^{[3][4]}
Latest release	1.0.1 December 17, 2004 ^[5]
Type of format	<u>Open file format</u> ^[6]
Extended to	<u>pandoc</u> , <u>MultiMarkdown</u> , <u>Markdown Extra</u> , <u>CommonMark</u> , ^[7] <u>RMarkdown</u> ^[8]
Website	<u>daringfireball.net/projects/markdown</u> / (<u>https://daringfireball.net/projects/markdown/</u>)

Rise and divergence

As Markdown's popularity grew rapidly, many Markdown implementations appeared, driven mostly by the need for additional features such as tables, footnotes, definition lists,^[note 1] and Markdown inside HTML blocks.

The behavior of some of these diverged from the reference implementation, as Markdown was only characterised by an informal specification^[17] and a Perl implementation for conversion to HTML.

At the same time, a number of ambiguities in the informal specification had attracted attention.^[18] These issues spurred the creation of tools such as Babelmark^{[19][20]} to compare the output of various implementations,^[21] and an effort by some developers of Markdown parsers for standardization. However, Gruber has argued that complete standardization would be a mistake: "Different sites (and people) have different needs. No one syntax would make all happy."^[22]

Gruber avoided using curly braces in Markdown to unofficially reserve them for implementation-specific extensions.^[23]

CommonMark

Standardization

In 2012, a group of people, including Jeff Atwood and John MacFarlane, launched what Atwood characterised as a standardization effort.^[12]

A community website now aims to "document various tools and resources available to document authors and developers, as well as implementors of the various Markdown implementations".^[26]

Name

In September 2014, Gruber objected to the usage of "Markdown" in the name of this effort and it was rebranded as "CommonMark".^{[13][27][28]} CommonMark.org published several versions of a specification, reference implementation, test suite, and "[plans] to announce a finalized 1.0 spec and test suite in 2019".^[29] A finalized 1.0 spec has not been released, as major issues still remain unsolved.^[30]

Adoption

Nonetheless, several websites and projects have adopted CommonMark, including Codeberg, Discourse, GitHub, GitLab, Reddit, Qt, Stack Exchange (Stack Overflow), and Swift.

CommonMark	
<u>Filename extensions</u>	.md, .markdown ^[2]
<u>Internet media type</u>	text/markdown; variant=CommonMark ^[7]
<u>Uniform Type Identifier (UTI)</u>	<i>uncertain</i> ^[24]
<u>UTI conformation</u>	public.plain-text
<u>Developed by</u>	<u>John MacFarlane</u> , open source
<u>Initial release</u>	October 25, 2014
<u>Latest release</u>	0.31.2 January 28, 2024 ^[25]
<u>Type of format</u>	<u>Open file format</u>
<u>Extended from</u>	Markdown
<u>Extended to</u>	<u>GitHub Flavored Markdown</u>
<u>Website</u>	<u>commonmark.org</u> (<u>https://commonmark.org/</u>) <u>spec</u> <u>.commonmark.org</u> (<u>http://spec.commonmark.org/</u>)

In March 2016, two relevant informational Internet RFCs were published:

- RFC 7763 (<https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc7763>) – "The text/markdown Media Type,"^[2] *Informational*.
Introduces MIME type `text/markdown`.
- RFC 7764 (<https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc7764>) – "Guidance on Markdown: Design Philosophies, Stability Strategies, and Select Registrations,"^[7] *Informational*.
Discusses and registers the variants MultiMarkdown, GitHub Flavored Markdown (GFM), Pandoc, and Markdown Extra (among others).^[31]

Variants

Websites like Bitbucket, Diaspora, Discord,^[32] GitHub,^[33] OpenStreetMap, Reddit,^[34] SourceForge^[35] and Stack Exchange^[36] use variants of Markdown to make discussions between users easier.

Depending on implementation, basic inline HTML tags may be supported.^[37]

Italic text may be implemented by `_underscores_` or `*single-asterisks*`.^[38]

GitHub Flavored Markdown

GitHub had been using its own variant of Markdown since as early as 2009,^[39] which added support for additional formatting such as tables and nesting block content inside list elements, as well as GitHub-specific features such as auto-linking references to commits, issues, usernames, etc.

In 2017, GitHub released a formal specification of its GitHub Flavored Markdown (<https://github.github.com/gfm/>) (GFM) that is based on CommonMark.^[33] It is a strict superset of CommonMark, following its specification exactly except for tables, strikethrough, autolinks and task lists, which GFM adds as extensions.^[40]

Accordingly, GitHub also changed the parser used on their sites, which required that some documents be changed. For instance, GFM now requires that the hash symbol that creates a heading be separated from the heading text by a space character.

Markdown Extra

Markdown Extra is a lightweight markup language based on Markdown implemented in PHP (originally), Python and Ruby.^[41] It adds the following features that are not available with regular Markdown:

- Markdown markup inside HTML blocks
- Elements with `id/class` attribute
- "Fenced code blocks" that span multiple lines of code
- Tables^[42]
- Definition lists
- Footnotes
- Abbreviations

Markdown Extra is supported in some content management systems such as Drupal,^[43] Grav (CMS), Textpattern CMS^[44] and TYPO3.^[45]

Examples

Text using Markdown syntax	Corresponding HTML produced by a Markdown processor	Text viewed in a browser
<pre>Heading ===== Sub-heading ----- # Alternative heading ## Alternative sub-heading Paragraphs are separated by a blank line. Two spaces at the end of a line produce a line break.</pre>	<pre><h1>Heading</h1> <h2>Sub-heading</h2> <h1>Alternative heading</h1> <h2>Alternative sub-heading</h2> <p>Paragraphs are separated by a blank line.</p> <p>Two spaces at the end of a line
 produce a line break.</p></pre>	Heading Sub-heading Alternative heading Alternative sub-heading Paragraphs are separated by a blank line. Two spaces at the end of a line produce a line break.
<pre>Text attributes _italic_, **bold**, `monospace`. Horizontal rule: ---</pre>	<pre><p>Text attributes italic, bold, <code>monospace</code>.</p> <p>Horizontal rule:</p> <hr /></pre>	Text attributes <i>italic</i>, bold, monospace. Horizontal rule:
<pre>Bullet lists nested within numbered list: 1. fruits * apple * banana 2. vegetables - carrot - broccoli</pre>	<pre><p>Bullet lists nested within numbered list:</p> fruits apple banana vegetables carrot broccoli </pre>	Bullet lists nested within numbered list: - fruits - apple - banana - vegetables - carrot - broccoli
<pre>A [link] (http://example.com). ![Image](Icon- pictures.png "icon") > Markdown uses email-style characters for</pre>	<pre><p>A link. </p> <p></p> <blockquote> <p>Markdown uses email-style</pre>	A link (http://example.com/).  Markdown uses email-style

<pre> blockquoting. > > Multiple paragraphs need to be prepended individually. Most inline <abbr title="Hypertext Markup Language">HTML</abbr> tags are supported. </pre>	<pre> characters for blockquoting.</p> <p>Multiple paragraphs need to be prepended individually.</p> </blockquote> <p>Most inline <abbr title="Hypertext Markup Language">HTML</abbr> tags are supported.</p> </pre>	Markdown uses email-style characters for blockquoting. Multiple paragraphs need to be prepended individually. Most inline HTML tags are supported.
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Implementations

Implementations of Markdown are available for over a dozen programming languages; in addition, many applications, platforms and frameworks support Markdown.^[46] For example, Markdown plugins exist for every major blogging platform.^[13]

While Markdown is a minimal markup language and is read and edited with a normal text editor, there are specially designed editors that preview the files with styles, which are available for all major platforms. Many general-purpose text and code editors have syntax highlighting plugins for Markdown built into them or available as optional download. Editors may feature a side-by-side preview window or render the code directly in a WYSIWYG fashion.

See also

- Comparison of document markup languages
- Comparison of documentation generators
- Comparison of wiki software
- Lightweight markup language
- List of markup languages
- List of text editors
- Wiki markup

Explanatory notes

- Technically HTML description lists

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offered by Hilton Lipschitz: *We no longer live in a 8.3 world, so we should be using the most descriptive file extensions. It's sad that all our operating systems rely on this stupid convention instead of the better creator code or a metadata model, but great that they now support longer file extensions.*"

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External links

- [Official website \(https://daringfireball.net/projects/markdown/\)](https://daringfireball.net/projects/markdown/) for original John Gruber markup
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Retrieved from "<https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Markdown&oldid=1353541055>"